

L4D2

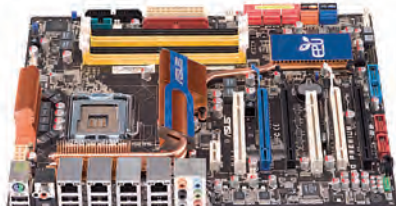
Left 4 Dead 2 game gets banned in Australia

Intel CULV

ASUS joins the Intel CULV processor bandwagon for its notebooks

Installing the heat sink isn't so much of an issue, but the board flexes sharply where the heat sink is fitted. The capacitors and MOSFETs are placed along one side of the processor while the other side is left relatively free and open. The only PCIe x1 slot on this board will be covered if the graphics card is put on the first slot. The second PCIe slot can be used for other cards, but it still will be very close to the graphics card.

The two P45-based boards from ASUS were the ASUS P5Q3 Deluxe Wi-Fi-AP @n and



ASUS P5Q Premium

ASUS P5Q Premium. The Wi-Fi-AP @n tag on the ASUS P5Q3 board denotes the inclusion of a Wi-Fi module that supports 802.11n. Both the boards use the ADI AD2000b sound chip instead of the usual Realtek ALC888. The difference in layout is the location of the SATA ports on the side. The P5Q Premium has all of them neatly stacked in a row where as the P5Q3 has a PATA port in between. The cooling is simpler with a solid heat sink only for the Southbridge with a blue EPU badge over it. The P5Q Premium comes with a larger version. Both boards are well laid out.

The MSI P43 Neo3 is a special board that has many more PCI slots than we've seen



ASUS P5Q3 Deluxe

on some of the other boards in this test. Other than the below-par processor mounting mechanism, it's a decent board with all the features including RAID using a JMicron chip. While all seems great with this board, once again, we're surprised to see a LPT and COM port at the back. The only PCIe x1 slot lie right below the PCIe x16 slot so adding any more PCIe cards might be impossible. Think carefully before buying this card. You have to resort to the other PCI slots for any other expansion.

Intel's DX48BT2 shares some similarities with the newer DX58SO board. Like the X58, there are no PS2 ports. Electrolytic capacitors are used all across the board. The SATA ports are also spaced out between where the PCIe graphics cards would normally go. Intel has tried to project this board as a performance board for gamers. For example, the package contains a fancy dog tag. The board has built in IR support so you can remotely control the PC. You'll need to purchase a remote and setup the software yourself through.

The other X48 board we received was the MSI X48C Platinum. MSI calls its cooling solution *Circupipe* and it is extensive. There is a set of three heat pipes running from the MOSFET coolers to the Northbridge which are then channelled to another two

heatsinks down the board. There are two PCIe x1 slots right next to the primary PCIe x16 slot. Three standard PCI slots follow the second PCIe x16 slot. This means you can easily plug in additional LAN or sound cards. The CMOS reset button is positioned behind the motherboard. The two buttons on the board are for the power and reset function. The biggest speciality of the board is the ability to use both DDR2 and DDR3 modules.

The Northbridge heat sink is pretty large with large fins and removing heatsinks can be a problem but obviously this isn't a major issue.

XFX's nForce 790i Ultra board uses the standard NVIDIA reference design. The 790 chipset gets very hot and especially so the Northbridge. The quality of the heat spreader isn't so great. Thankfully, a fan is provided which very neatly fits on the Northbridge heat sink. The processor is surrounded by a range of heatsinks and heat pipes connecting them together. Although this is a pretty high-end board, there are a lot of electrolytic capacitors used.

There are dedicated buttons for the power and reset which is handy. There's also a LED poster on the side. There are SATA ports lined up on one side in between the RAM slots and the PATA connector. The first two SATA ports are lined up right at the bottom of the board. The bundle is nice too. There are narrow rounded PATA cables and plenty of black SATA cables that go well with the colour scheme of the board.

ZOTAC's 780i Supreme board is almost identical to the XFX nForce 790i Ultra SLI with minor differences here and there. In terms of design, the Northbridge heat sink isn't as wide as the one on the XFX 790i board. There are solid state capacitors again along the processor. There's a Wi-Fi module bundled with the board. The cables in the package aren't rounded or anything. There are molex to SATA power converters bundled with the board in case you're using a really old power supply that only came with molex power connectors.

The Striker II NSE is ASUS's NVIDIA-powered high-end for the LGA775 platform. It uses the top-of-the-line nForce 790i SLI chipset. It looks a

lot different from the other NVIDIA based boards we've seen. This ROG-series board has a good SupremeFX II add-on module which comes with a shield to reduce any kind of interference that an on-board audio chip would pickup. The quality of the board might not be anything spectacular as compared to dedicated high-end sound cards but they're a big step on any on-board audio solution for sure. The board has the provision for water cooling although the water block looks separated from the rest of the heat sink and heat pipes. The bundle comes with pipe fittings adaptors and screws needed to fit the water cooling kit. It's showy looking too – the heatsinks and fins are contoured with strips of metal which gives the board a very clean look. There's also the glowing *Republic of Gamers* badge next to the Northbridge heat sink. The power and reset buttons are on the board and the CMOS reset button at the back. Although the sides of the



Zotac 790i Ultra SLI

processors are all lined up with heat pipes and heatsinks, most of the area around it is kept clear.

Performance

Even after a really lengthy session of testing, we weren't expecting too many surprises with the performance. Synthetic benchmarks like 3DMark and PCMark05 stayed more or less within the expected range. There were hardly any variations in the video encoding tests as well. It has to be said that the P45 chipset generally tops the scores. The P35 was a stable and a one that was used for a long time. The P45 builds on that and is probably one of the refined chipsets around.

